

Process Essay

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Part One:

• What inspired you to pursue this work?

During the summer of 2023, I had the privilege of meeting 30 other high school journalists like me and many experienced reporters and mentors in a summer journalism program. Throughout the week there, by day we trained our technical and social journalistic skills. By night, our mentors shared the emotional and ethical challenges of their work. I have seven years of journalism experience, but these were stories I had never heard of before—as stories from journalists are everywhere, but stories about journalists tend to get buried by the former. These journalists, regardless of what news outlet they work for, have experienced deep trauma from personal and social positioning and taken on the lessons and strife of the thousands of lives they've interviewed, but nonetheless report and write with strong convictions. Coming face-to-face with the journalists who shared with me their stories of struggle and success, I felt grateful they were willing to be vulnerable with me. From that weeklong summer camp, I emerged knowing journalism not as a line of work, but as a value to truth-seeking.

This experience influenced my own convictions as well: as a journalist, I began writing with specificity in my language, now aware of the objective and subjective possibilities readers can take away from my writing. I realized the weaknesses and strengths in my writing, namely that I felt a deep responsibility to tie my subject to social and cultural shifts shaped by economic and political implications. But rather than end all my articles broadly, I learned to stay specific and pinpointed in that story's subject by "showing my work" in how I arrived at a conclusion in my writing. I believe that's what it means to be a writer of the American narrative.

More recently, in October 2024, my mentor and Washington Post reporter Arelis Hernández posted a few Stories on her Instagram account responding to ugly reader emails. Before we dismiss this as a regular ugly email, this was a human-interest story about resilience and the American Dream which these emails politicized as a target for xenophobic and racist rhetoric—producing responses from some readers blaming immigrants for issues in society and suggesting the deportation of millions of people. On top of it, these emails direct their frustration with immigrants to Hernández's Cuban identity. She said, "I know many of us [journalists] get these notes. Because our bylines and stories are magnets for them. This is what happens [when] you tell stories about communities who help expand and enrich the definition of American. We don't and I don't write these stories porque nos da la gana but because it's true and accurate to the larger narrative of a story like coastal climate disaster."

So I emerge once more knowing journalism's value to truth-seeking is actually a commitment to shaping public discourse and democracy. Despite the hostility, Hernández encourages other journalists to continue doing meaningful work and to stay fearless and unapologetic in telling stories that highlight the diversity and challenges of American communities. In my view, that is the beauty of journalism. Journalism goes beyond a traditional definition as a process of

gathering, writing, editing, and disseminating information through media, or a career for people who practice journalism. It is a value. That value is what I explore in my paper, examining the historical evolution of journalism, the rise of fake news, and the role of media literacy in the modern digital age.

• **How much time (hours/days/months) did it take you to complete this work?**

This project took several months to complete, from August 2024 to January 2025. The research phase alone spanned about thirteen weeks, during which I examined historical texts, journalism case studies, and academic theories. Each week, I spent approximately 7-8 hours researching. Writing and refining my arguments took an additional month (7-8 hours per week), as I sought to connect historical perspectives with modern media trends. Finally, I took a few weeks dedicated to revising my paper (5 hours per week) based on feedback from my mentor and peers.

• **How did you organize the work that went into doing it?**

I structured my research into three key areas: historical shifts in journalism, the impact of sensationalism and fake news, and the importance of media literacy. During the topic ideation phase of my project, I already had a general outline of my project, starting from the past then finally focusing on the present political and economic implications on journalism. I maintained a research journal to track sources and key arguments, which helped me draw connections between historical events and contemporary issues. After drafting my paper, I revised each section for clarity and coherence, refining my arguments based on feedback.

• **What difficulties did you encounter and how did you handle them?**

One of the biggest challenges was condensing complex historical narratives into a cohesive argument. The evolution of journalism spans centuries, and I had to decide which events and theories were most relevant. To address this, I focused on key moments—such as the rise of yellow journalism and the digital age—that significantly shaped public perception of the media. Another challenge was ensuring that my analysis remained objective while discussing issues like media bias and misinformation. To overcome this, I relied on academic sources and historical evidence to support my claims.

Part Two:

• **Where was the work completed?**

I conducted most of my research in in-person public and university libraries and online archives, drawing from historical newspapers, scholarly articles, and books on journalism and media history. Writing took place in a combination of school study spaces, my dorm at school, home, and local cafes to focus on synthesizing my ideas.

• **What help have you received in doing this work?**

During the research phase of my project, my research mentor and teacher Dr. Cantrell gave me resources for online archives for me to find historical papers and such for evidence. He also taught me how to build an argument, make evidence evidentiary, and how to structure a research paper.

In the revision phase, to better inform and revise my arguments and evidence, I consulted my journalism mentors and peers for their opinions, experiences, and thoughts on my writing. I am the editor-in-chief of my school's student newspaper, so I was also able to present my paper for feedback from my editorial board of 15 student journalists. Our conversations gave me a lot of insight on what time period and what claims and evidence they had, outside of what I already knew.

Additionally, I brought my research journal to my humanities courses, making notes of methods and texts I encountered throughout my literature analyses especially in my Research in the Humanities class. I learned how to source and analyze a text through reading Gothic literature and essays like Roland Barthes' "Camera Lucida," Arundhati Roy's "The Greater Common Good," and Kimberlé Crenshaw's "Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex."

• Was your project completed through a paid program/mentorship? If yes, which one, who did you work with and in what capacity?

This project was independently researched and written, under a free research program at my high school called Research in the Humanities, led by Dr. Cantrell and containing about 70 students total. Additionally, my experience in the journalism program, called the Asian American Journalists Association (AAJA) JCamp, at American University deeply influenced my perspective, and I drew upon the lessons learned from my mentors in shaping my argument.